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Ban the ban hammer

Recent reported bans on certain games in India and China make no sense at all

Arnab Mukherjee | arnab@digit.in

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he glorious world of gaming needs no introduction and neither does the campaign that

highlights its supposed 'adverse' effects. While it is true that there are several adverse effects of gaming, as studies have pointed out, most of them are physical which stem from an unhealthy amount of gaming being a routine practice. However, that doesn't stop people from taking steps against it as evidenced by the recent spate of bans in India and China directed at gamers and games.

Recent rumours based on forum posts and other sources seem to indicate that China's recently established Online Ethics Review Committee has recommended bans on nine popular games - mainly battle royale titles - for failing to pass "social and ethical rules". It has also highlighted corrective actions for multiple other titles for the same reasons. To be specific, titles like Fortnite, PUBG, H1Z1, Ring of Elysium and Paladins have been marked as restricted or withdrawn due to "blood and gore" and "vulgar content". Titles like Riot's League of Legends and Activision Blizzard titles such as Overwatch, Diablo and World of Warcraft were not recommended for a ban outright but received warnings to take "corrective action" in order meet the standards of the committee.

First of all, there's something highly fishy about this, so fishy, in fact, that

this may not be true. There's little to no evidence confirming these bans - officials representing some companies on this list have said they can "neither confirm nor deny" these reports. We all know how reassuring that is. However, even if this does turn out to be true, it makes little sense. For instance, Fortnite is being banned for blood and gore when the game, literally, doesn't have any. Both Overwatch and League of Legends have been recommended corrective action - but LoL has 'Overly

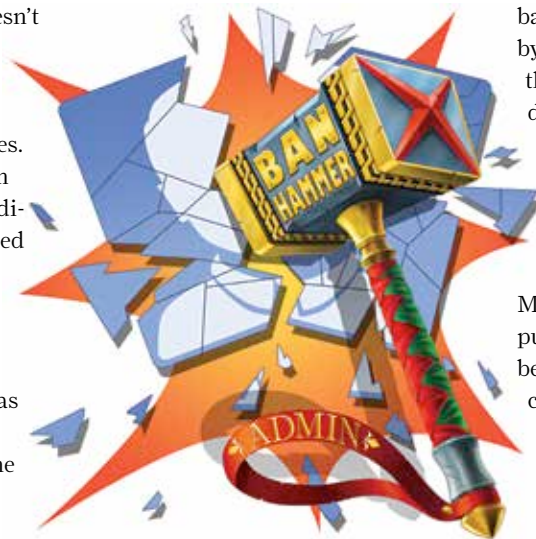
taken seriously is an indicator of how ridiculous things have become.

Speaking of ridiculous, recently Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT) in India announced a ban on PUBG and 'games like it' in VIT, which supposedly includes the campus and its hostels. The reasons cited? It disturbs fellow roommates and spoils the overall hostel atmosphere.

There are some bans on hostel premises that do make sense. Banning alcohol and loud music is in the best interests of all the students. However, banning a mobile game being played by adults on their own smartphones in their own hostel rooms is borderline dictatorial. As any hosteler, current or former, would gladly tell you, at any given time there are way too many things that can 'bother' a fellow hosteler significantly more than a mobile game can.

Most people who play PUBG seriously put on headphones anyways. We also believe that any adult has the right to choose a mode of entertainment that is not forbidden by the law.

If this doesn't stop here it can pretty easily lead to a landslide. Indian colleges and universities are already well known for their regressive bans on clothing, music choices and more. What next? Ban watching stand-up specials on Netflix because fellow hostelers are disturbed by laughter? Ban eating chips in their rooms because the crunch is too loud? The scary part is, any of these could be done tomorrow by an institution and it wouldn't seem too out of place here. But that's something for another edition of Rantz. 



revealing female characters' as a cause whereas Overwatch doesn't! One word - Widowmaker. Another reason why this seems fishy is that Tencent, one of China's biggest conglomerates and a massive game publisher, has recently made huge investments and signed pacts with the Chinese Government to bring PUBG and Fortnite to China. We have to truly wait and watch how this plays out, but the fact that this is being